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turous type, this problem is simply compounded by the lack of access to electricity.

Your prayers seem to have been answered. O'Neill's H2 series of backpacks is what you should be looking at. The H2 series integrates two flexible solar panels with necessary electronics to control communication and entertainment devices.

The solar panels generate power during favourable lighting conditions and supply it to your iPod, mobile phone and integrated Bluetooth module via a USB connection. The system also has an electronic board that senses which device is in the most need of power and smartly allocates it accordingly.

Apart from the solar panel, the backpack also has an integrated Bluetooth module for handsfree calling. A microphone is built into the left shoulder strap and a universal headphone jack is integrated in the chest pocket. Moreover, when you get a call, the iPod is automatically paused till the call ends.

Both—the iPod and Bluetooth module—is stowed away in discrete water-resistant compartments. A soft, washable, fabric control panel is placed on the left shoulder strap to control playback of the iPod without having to reach for the device deep inside the pack.

The backpack is constructed from ultra-light and strong nylon for maximum durability. The pack also incorporates a snowboard carry system, shovel stash and compression straps. Prices are not yet out, but we fear they will be astronomical. Adventure calls!

HP ep9012 Instant Cinema Digital Projector

The ep9012 from HP is an all-in-one projection solution for home users combining the ambience of a projector, fidelity of a 2.1 sound system and the versatility of a DVD player.

The projector is based around DLP technology and delivers sharp and crystal clear images. For better colour saturation and depth, a six-segment colour wheel makes into the projector. The 840 lumen built-in lamp offers enough brightness and contrast for big screen viewing at home.

The integrated DVD player can play DVD-video and DVD±R/RW straight from the projector.

The DVD player also supports VCD, SVCD, CD-R, CD-RW, CD-audio and MP3 audio formats for maximum versatility. Other interesting features include playing JPEG files from a CD directly as a slideshow; just short of allowing direct camera connection.

To complete the cinematic experience, the system is equipped with a 2.1 speaker system. It has two speakers on each side, capable of delivering 20W and a third 30W sub-woofer base for bass. For a full immersive aural experience you can connect the ep9012 to any 5.1 enabled home theatre system.

The ep9012 is further equipped with S-video, composite video, component video, PC DVI and VGA (via adapter) inputs. To make it future proof the ep9012 is HDTV ready. Expected price for the ep9012 is around \$2000 (Rs 87,000), so get ready for a compact home entertainment system.

Microsoft Xbox 360

Microsoft's soon-to-be-released next generation gaming console—the Xbox 360—takes convergence to the next level. While the gaming aspect is at the core of its design, looking at the specs and the functionality one can't argue the fact that it is more than just a gaming console.

The new Xbox is supposed to derive its computing power from a triple core processor running at 3.2 GHz, where each core is capable of running two threads simultaneously, leading to generation of six



Microsoft's Xbox 360 that's making waves, and Archos' PMA400

threads at once. Such huge reserves of computing power means a lot of data can be thrown at the CPU for the ultimate gaming experience.

The graphics section is handled by a custom-made ATI chip with 512 MB GDDR3 RAM and a 10 MB frame buffer. The chip also has 48 Shader units working on a new Shader language to deliver the best eye candy ever seen on a console.

Storage is provided via a detachable 20 GB hard drive which can further be upgraded when you run out of space. The Xbox 360 comes with a 12X dual layer DVD drive and will support most formats including WMA and MP3 CDs. The console also has two memory unit slots.

On the I/O front, the console offers three USB 2.0 ports for connecting it to a PC, has an Ethernet port, is wireless-ready supporting 802.11a, b and g standards and is video camera-ready.

Further, you can stream media from portable devices, digital cameras, Windows XP PCs and can rip music to the Xbox 360's hard drive. It also comes with a Windows Media Centre extender built-in.

Archos PMA400

Archos Pocket Media Assistant400, as the name suggests, is a portable media player that also acts as a digital assistant. Based on a Linux platform, the PMA400 offers class-leading features in a small and compact structure.

The PMA400 can record directly from your TV, VCR, cable box or a satellite receiver with the help of a cradle that comes with the package. The device also allows transferring of media from a Windows PC or a MAC on to its 30 GB hard drive. The recording is saved in MPEG4-SP format and the device can playback MPEG4-SP videos with soundtrack in MP3 format up to a resolution of 704 x 480 at 30 fps.